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How a Hawiye tribe used to live

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Place Coverage

Hawiye; Somalia, Djibouti, and southeastern Ethiopia

Section Title(S)

1. Contrast between 'Am[unknown]udi and Ya[unknown]q[unknown]ub.

Ya[unknown]q[unknown]ub: I am Abgâl, I am one of the men who have been governing because of their ancestors and did not descend from she-camels; whose dominion is in their mouth and against whom nothing can be (⁴).

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'Am[unknown]udi: The burânbur is my field, it is my savings and a thing to which I have been accustomed; it is what I came out for, and we do not fatten by lies (⁵).

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Ya[unknown]q[unknown]ub: I know that I am Abgâl; I am going to my country:
The people from whom my grandfathers used to borrow the provisions: I
cannot tolerate their arrogance (⁶).

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'Am[unknown]judi: If you have the band of your badge cut from you, you are no
longer worth anything: Emigrate away from our seats,  93 O cultivator of
clearings and loader of caravans (⁷).

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. The Ya[unknown]q[unknown]ub singer again celebrates the nobility of his people, whose genealogy has as founder Ab-g[unknown]al (with a pun between g[unknown]al, 'he-camel' [cf. above, p. 66], and hal, 'she-camel': the people have virile war traditions, whereas for the 'Am[unknown]judi one is able to think only of a female as the genealogical founder, therefore a she-camel in contrast to the g[unknown]al, 'he-camel,' of the Abg[unknown]al).

. The buranbur dance, to whose rhythm this strophe was sung, is the absolute property of the slaves of the 'Am[unknown]judi (thus an 'Am[unknown]judi poetess servant intervened in the contrast). It is not allowed for foreigners.

. The Ya[unknown]q[unknown]ub poet uses irony concerning the city 'Am[unknown]judi devoted to trade and credit, professions considered evil by the free pastoralists.

. The 'Am[unknown]judi singer invites the Ya[unknown]q[unknown]ub to leave the city to the citizens; and in turn he jokes about the occupations of the Somalis of the woodland, cameleers or cultivators of the small clearings (g[unknown]of) or in the service of the Government with a badge of a red ribbon at the neck, which was worn at that time (cf. here above, p. 52).

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